

Illinois Coalition for Immigrant and Refugee Rights

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WIC Modernization and Delivery

When considering changes to the WIC program, we would suggest that the following areas of focus should be forefront in policy makers' minds: the clients' cultural background, their specific needs, and their limitations.

Low-income WIC clients (specifically mothers who receive WIC benefits) encounter an array of challenges that prohibit their continued enrollment in the WIC program over a period of years. Some of these factors include: long work hours, addressing the needs of their other children, lack of transportation, unavailability during WIC office business hours, and being unable to attend the nutritional classes provided by WIC.

The Center should evaluate the needs of the WIC state agency by concentrating on the population of each state and their disparate cultural backgrounds. Due to the limited culturally appropriate ingredients in the WIC food lists, ethnic communities often encounter difficulty determining how to cook using the food in the Authorized WIC Food List. In fact, many clients only use very specific items from the list. Expanding and including a greater variety of culturally appropriate food will help clients to continue to claim their WIC benefits. Additionally, expanding access to locations where foods can be purchased would also be an important step in the sustainability of the WIC program. Lastly, expanding the eligibility requirements for clients to continue their WIC benefits would go a long way in keeping clients enrolled.

The Center should also have WIC information and guidelines in multiple languages that address the language needs of each state. In Illinois, for example, *the top five languages spoken are Spanish, Polish, Chinese, Tagalog, and Arabic. It is pivotal to share information, best practices, or other issues that impact the customer experience in a minimum of the top five languages spoken.

To define and measure success, The Center ought to determine precisely why clients disenroll or discontinue using WIC benefits. Comparing the number of people applying for WIC benefits to how long they use the benefits will create data points to analyze rates of disenrollment. Oftentimes clients will apply for WIC benefits to receive milk formula, however, given the burdensome requirements of the program, they disenroll as soon as their child stops drinking the formula. Even though WIC is a supplementary nutritional program, clients often prefer to only receive SNAP (due to fewer restrictions). When participating in the SNAP program, clients may purchase food at a variety of locations and they are not required to participate in additional nutritional classes.

To conclude, one must secure stakeholders' input to best design the modernization and improved delivery of the WIC program itself.

*“The Demographic Statistical Atlas of the United States - Statistical Atlas.” *The Demographic Statistical Atlas of the United States - Statistical Atlas*,
<https://statisticalatlas.com/state/Illinois/Languages>. Accessed 8 Dec. 2021.

Illinois Coalition for Immigrant and Refugee Rights (ICIRR)

ICIRR is dedicated to promoting the rights of immigrants and refugees to full and equal participation in the civic, cultural, social, and political life of our diverse society.